Elicitation Interview Findings

Interview Summaries

Interview 1: Preference-Driven Gamer

The first interviewee primarily relies on personal interests, recommendations from friends, and YouTube videos when deciding whether to play a game. Their decision to purchase a game is strongly influenced by its difficulty, graphics, and multiplayer features when applicable. They do not rely heavily on numerical scores or public reviews because they believe that individual preferences differ too much for general ratings to be consistently useful.

The interviewee values reviews that are personal, detailed, and explain the reasoning behind the reviewer's opinion. They are particularly critical of review bombing, popularity-driven praise, and reviewers who criticize games for features that do not match their own preferences. Although they see some value in a website that collects reviews from multiple sources, they would want to filter those sources and evaluate the information independently rather than rely on an overall rating.

Interview 2: Trusted-Source and Comparison-Oriented Gamer

The second interviewee primarily uses recommendations from friends, YouTube videos, and Steam when evaluating games. Their decisions are influenced by genre, difficulty, gameplay, performance, price, multiplayer activity, and whether a game continues to receive updates. They also consider brand loyalty and their experiences with previous games in a series.

The interviewee prefers recommendations from people whose gaming interests align with their own and is skeptical of reviews influenced by politics or other factors unrelated to gameplay. They are interested in a centralized website that allows them to compare games, filter by relevant characteristics, and examine ratings from different sources. However, they would need to see evidence that the website represents reviews fairly before trusting its results. They also expressed interest in comparing ratings from the same reviewer across multiple games and potentially prioritizing reviews from their Steam friends.

Shared Findings

Both interviewees rely more heavily on personal preferences and trusted recommendations than on general public opinion when deciding whether a game is worth

playing. Friends and YouTube are important information sources for both, and neither considers a game's overall public rating sufficient to determine whether they will enjoy it.

Both interviewees want to understand the reasoning behind reviews rather than relying exclusively on numerical scores. They recognize that reviewers have different preferences and that a negative review does not necessarily indicate that a game is unsuitable for everyone. Both also expressed concerns about review manipulation, including review bombing and popularity-driven praise, as well as reviewers criticizing games for reasons that do not align with their own interests.

The interviews suggest that users could benefit from a website that consolidates review information while allowing them to evaluate individual sources. However, collecting ratings from multiple sources alone may not be enough to establish trust. Users need context about who provided the reviews, what those reviewers value, and why they reached their conclusions.

The following potential system needs emerged from these shared findings:

Users need access to information about the origins of reviews and ratings.

Users need to understand the reasoning behind reviewers' opinions when that information is available.

Users need to evaluate games according to their own interests rather than relying solely on aggregate ratings.

Users need ways to compare relevant game characteristics and identify games that match their preferences.

Users need transparent information about how ratings are collected and combined, if the system provides an aggregate rating.

Individual Findings

Although the interviewees shared several preferences, each also identified needs that were not explicitly established by both interviews.

Interviewee 1

The first interviewee emphasized that general public opinion has limited value because different players enjoy different game characteristics. Difficulty, graphics, and multiplayer features were particularly important when evaluating a game.

The interviewee expressed some interest in viewing reviews from multiple sources in one location and filtering those sources. However, they indicated that consolidating reviews

would not necessarily change their reliance on personal judgment and recommendations from friends.

This interview suggests that the system should prioritize access to review explanations and relevant game characteristics rather than assuming that users want a single score to determine whether a game is worth playing.

Potential needs identified:

The ability to filter review information by source.

Access to detailed explanations of reviewers' opinions.

Information about game characteristics that affect personal enjoyment, particularly difficulty, graphics, and multiplayer features.

Interviewee 2

The second interviewee expressed greater interest in using a centralized review website to discover and compare games. They described potentially using the website when looking for something new to play, considering a game during a sale, or comparing games within the same genre.

They also suggested comparing scores assigned by the same reviewer across different games. This could help users understand a reviewer's preferences and evaluate whether their opinions are relevant to a particular user. The interviewee also expressed interest in filtering games by genre, difficulty, and platform, as well as examining review sources separately.

Other suggestions included prioritizing reviews from Steam friends, accounting for mod support, and identifying when reviews were published. The interviewee also emphasized the importance of establishing a reliable track record before trusting the website.

Potential needs identified:

The ability to compare multiple games using selected characteristics.

The ability to examine ratings from the same reviewer across different games.

The ability to view ratings from individual sources and understand how an aggregate rating was calculated.

The ability to filter games by genre, difficulty, and platform.

Access to information about review publication dates and game modifications.

Potential integration with Steam to prioritize reviews from friends, subject to technical feasibility and available permissions.

Open Questions

The interviews identified several areas that require additional stakeholder input or technical investigation before the team finalizes its requirements.

User Needs and Expected Functionality

Aggregate ratings: Should the website calculate an overall rating, display ratings from individual sources, or provide both options?

Personalization: How should users indicate their gaming preferences, and which filters would be most useful? Potential filters include genre, difficulty, platform, multiplayer features, and other game characteristics.

Trusted sources: Should the system prioritize reviews from friends, professional reviewers, user-review platforms, or sources selected by the user?

Reviewer comparisons: Would comparing a reviewer's ratings across multiple games help users evaluate that reviewer's credibility and relevance?

Game updates: How should the website communicate whether a review reflects the current version of a game, particularly when major updates change its performance or gameplay?

Mod support: Should the system include information about available modifications, and how important is this information to the intended users?

User accounts and integrations: Would users benefit from connecting accounts such as Steam to personalize results or prioritize reviews from friends?

Trust and Rating Transparency

Source selection: Which review sources should the website include, and how should the team determine whether a source is suitable?

Bias and review manipulation: How should the website present potentially biased or manipulated reviews without making unsupported judgments about reviewers' intentions?

Rating calculations: If the website combines ratings, what calculation method should it use, and how should it explain that method to users?

Missing information: How should the system handle games with few reviews, sources that do not provide numerical ratings, or reviews that cannot be retrieved?

Technical Feasibility

Data availability: Which review platforms provide accessible data, and what technical restrictions, API requirements, or licensing conditions apply?

Source consistency: Can ratings and review information from different sources be represented consistently without losing important context?

Implementation scope: Which proposed features can the team realistically implement within the project's time and resource constraints?

External integrations: Is integrating with platforms such as Steam technically feasible and appropriate for the project's initial version?

These questions should be prioritized according to the project's scope and the importance of the decisions they affect. Additional interviews with other types of stakeholders, particularly people who regularly use professional reviews or review aggregation websites, could help validate whether the needs identified in these interviews apply to a broader range of users.